

What Every Judge Needs to Know About Scoring

Entering interview scores at ISEF is very easy and can be done through any device capable of running a web browser. Most judges use their personal smartphone for this purpose.

What do I submit in the scoring app?

The scoring app allows you to record a score and/or a private note for any project in your category. Entering a score does not require a note; entering a note does not require a score.

Valid scores are all integers from 0-100 inclusive, and only those integers. The scoring app will refuse to accept any other input.

Notes can be any text you want (including blank text if you want to delete a note).

Who can see my scores and notes?

Your submissions to the scoring app are visible only to you and to your category co-chairs. Students will never see your scores or notes.¹

However, during caucusing it sometimes proves useful for the caucus to drill down below the summary information provided in the standard caucus displays. If the co-chairs do drill down for more information on a specific project, your score and note for that project will be visible to all judges in the caucus room.

How soon can I submit scores and notes?

You can enter notes at any time after the scoring app goes live, which should be several days prior to the interviews.

On the other hand, you cannot enter any scores until sometime during Interview Period #1 on Wednesday. Before then, you will not have enough information to determine a valid score for any project. However, in preparation for giving a score you should save preliminary impressions based upon online and display materials provided by the student.

When should I submit scores?

You should submit scores incrementally throughout the interview day, as you determine them. Do not wait a few interviews to “calibrate” your scoring. If subsequent interviews convince you that your first few scores were too high, or too low, you can easily update them later.

After the final interview period, you will gather with all other judges in your assigned category room to caucus for all award decisions. The first order of business will be for the category co-chairs to ensure that all judges have entered all scores. When they are satisfied that everyone

¹ If you *do* want to communicate anything to a student after the fair, see “Communicating with Students Outside of ISEF Judging” within document *H: Ethical Concerns for Judges* in Section II of the *Judge Information Board*.

has submitted all of the scores that they plan to enter, then in plain view of everyone in the room, they will press the “Begin Caucus” button to begin caucusing. Once your category co-chair presses that button, the scoring app will reject any further submissions of scores or notes.

Updating Scores and Notes

After you have entered a score or a note for a given project, you can change that score to any legal value, and revise your note, as many times as you want until caucusing begins.

Tie Scores

While it is possible to give the same score to more than one project, doing so is discouraged.

Every year some judges are so impressed by two (or more) projects that they give their top score (even a score of 100) to both (or all), thinking that this should help their projects toward awards. In fact, it will hurt your most-favored project. The reason is that all projects that are tied are given the *average* rank that would have been given to the *entire set* had they not been tied. In other words, if only the judge had given unique scores to each and chose the project they thought was the best, that project would have gotten a higher rank at the end of the day. By giving a tie, the judge therefore lowered their favorite project’s rank.

If you would like to delve into the details on how ISEF processes your scores into the displays presented to your category caucus, see document A: *Scores: What Happens to Them, and Why They Matter* in Section IV of the *Judge Information Board*.

How do I correct a mistake?

The answer depends upon the kind of mistake that you made and when you discover it. You can always overwrite notes on any project until caucusing begins.

Scores, though, are different.

If before caucusing begins you want to *change* a score you have already given, then simply enter the new score and hit “Submit.”

On the other hand, if you mistakenly entered a score for a project that you did not interview, it is *impossible* for you to erase that score on your own. **You cannot remove a score by entering a blank or a zero.** A blank score will simply preserve whatever you had originally submitted. Entering zero, which is a valid score, will saddle the project with the lowest possible score which it undoubtedly does not deserve.

Instead, in order to remove a score, you must inform one of your category co-chairs that you assigned a score to the wrong project and need it vacated. The co-chair will need to record your name, your Judgeld, the project number, and the score given in order to pass the request on to the staff who can vacate the score.

If you do not discover a scoring mistake until after caucusing begins, then it is too late to fix it. This is why co-chairs will make a point of having *all judges confirm that all scoring is complete* before they will hit the “Begin Caucus” button.

Points of Emphasis

1. Valid scores are all integers from 0-100 inclusive, and only those values.
2. Tie scores are allowed, but discouraged. If you tie your top projects, you may take your favorite project out of the running for a top award.
3. You can change scores and notes as often as you want until caucusing begins.
4. Once you submit a score, you cannot remove it. If you entered a score for the wrong project, you must contact one of your category co-chairs who will forward the removal request to a system administrator.